



# Online Selling

Selling online gives you access to a much wider market, while also saving on the cost of a “bricks-and-mortar” shop. There are several platforms you can use to sell to customers.

## Identifying online opportunities

There are obvious advantages to selling your products online, such as avoiding the ongoing expense of maintaining a physical shop, being able to sell at any time of day or night, and reaching a much wider market. On the other hand, you face the challenges of customers being able to find you when searching online (see pp.118–119) and having to compete with all the other thousands of offerings on the internet.

To sell online, you have a number of options: to set up your own website; to use an e-commerce site-builder; or to sell your products through an online marketplace.

## Using third-party sites

While creating your own site gives you complete control over how it looks and functions (see pp.114–117), it takes time, money, and expertise. In contrast,

## Choosing your platform

There are several ways you can sell online, with advantages and disadvantages to each approach. The platform you choose will depend on your product. If selling a personal service, then your own website may be preferable. If your product is very expensive, you may want to choose an online marketplace that charges a smaller commission on your sale—or even use a range of platforms for your various products.

In 2018, online global  
e-retail sales amounted to  
**\$2.8tn**

Office for National Statistics, 2020

### Your own website



Building your own website allows you to create a virtual shopping experience that reflects your brand. You can also use additional software, allowing your site to take secure payments, and process invoices and shipments.

#### PROS

- **Website promotes** your unique brand
- **Easy to change** when necessary and according to how shoppers use it
- **No concerns** about changing internal algorithms, as found on online marketplaces, such as Amazon
- **Easy to tailor your structure** to improve searchability using search engine optimization

#### CONS

- **Takes time and money** to maintain, market, and host online
- **Requires technical knowledge** to create and maintain
- **Payment and data security** are essential and your responsibility: you will be liable for any breaches
- **Larger competitors' websites** are easy to find and may offer customers a better shopping experience

